

The Early Church Councils, Their Creeds, and the Biblical Canon

What the councils actually decided - and why saying they "created the Bible" is historically unfair

A council-by-council examination with primary-source evidence, full creed texts, disciplinary canons, and comparative canon lists

Central conclusion

Nicaea did not select the books of the Bible. The great ecumenical councils chiefly defined doctrine and church order. The regional synods that did list biblical books described them as received and suitable for church reading, not as newly made authoritative by a vote.

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Executive summary

The decisive distinction

A disciplinary canon is a rule enacted by a council. The biblical canon is the collection of books received as Scripture. The fact that a council issued canons does not mean it issued a canon of Scripture.

The surviving records of Nicaea contain a creed, a synodal letter, a decision concerning Easter, and twenty disciplinary canons. None lists biblical books. Constantinople, Ephesus, and Chalcedon likewise concentrated on Trinitarian and Christological doctrine, jurisdiction, clergy, worship, and discipline. Their importance is enormous, but it is not the importance commonly assigned to them by the modern "Nicaea chose the Bible" story.^[1]

Laodicea, Hippo, and Carthage are more directly relevant because they addressed books read in church. Yet their language is regulatory and receptive. Laodicea forbids uncanonical books from public reading; Carthage says its listed books were "received from our fathers" to be read in church. These councils did not claim that their vote caused a book to become inspired.^[2]

The evidence before these councils also matters. Eusebius, writing around the time of Nicaea, could already distinguish accepted, disputed, rejected, and heretical writings. Athanasius listed the same twenty-seven New Testament books used today in 367, before Hippo and Carthage. This pattern is better described as gradual recognition with a strong early core and a smaller disputed edge.^[3]

1. The two meanings of "canon"

The word canon can create confusion because it is used in two related but different ways. In conciliar history, a canon is an ecclesiastical rule: for example, a rule governing ordination, appeals, the movement of clergy, or the conduct of worship. In biblical studies, the canon is the recognized collection of scriptural books.

The Council of Nicaea produced twenty canons in the first sense. It produced no canon list in the second sense. Therefore, a statement such as "Nicaea established the canon" can sound plausible only when the two meanings are unconsciously blended.

Recognition is not nothing

To say that councils recognized or regulated the canon does not make them irrelevant. Their decisions could stabilize public worship, exclude forged works, settle local uncertainty, and record a broad consensus. The narrower claim is that these actions did not create inspiration or apostolic authority.

2. Evidence before the famous canon councils

The fourfold Gospel and a strong early core

By the late second century, writers such as Irenaeus argued explicitly for four and only four Gospels. Christian authors across different regions cited the Gospels, Acts, Paul, 1 Peter, and 1 John as authoritative well before any fourth-century council issued a book list. The core was therefore not waiting for Nicaea to exist.

The Muratorian Fragment

The Muratorian Fragment is an early list, traditionally dated to the late second century, though its date remains debated. Its beginning is damaged, but it recognizes Luke and John, Acts, thirteen Pauline letters, Jude, at least two Johannine letters, and Revelation. It rejects forged letters associated with Marcion and treats the Shepherd of Hermas as useful but too recent for public reading among the prophets or apostles. The document is valuable because it shows criteria already at work: apostolicity, antiquity, doctrinal fidelity, and liturgical use.^[4]

Origen and Eusebius: accepted books and disputed edges

Origen knew the four Gospels and the Pauline collection, but also reported uncertainty about the human author of Hebrews and about several shorter letters. Eusebius later organized the evidence into categories. He placed James, Jude, 2 Peter, and 2-3 John among disputed writings nevertheless known to many; Revelation appeared on both sides of his discussion because some accepted it and others rejected it. He separately listed works such as the Shepherd, Barnabas, the Didache, and the Apocalypse of Peter among rejected or non-universal writings.^[5]

What this evidence proves

The church did not possess perfect uniformity in every location, but neither did it face a shapeless pile of equally plausible books. A broad core existed before Nicaea; disagreements clustered around a relatively small number of writings.

Athanasius in 367

Athanasius's Thirty-Ninth Festal Letter is the first surviving list that names exactly the twenty-seven books of the present New Testament. He calls them books "included in the Canon, and handed down, and accredited as Divine." He also distinguishes a second category of books appointed to be read for instruction, including Wisdom, Sirach, Judith, Tobit, the Didache, and the Shepherd. This is direct evidence that an influential bishop could distinguish canonical books from useful church books without claiming to invent either category.^[6]

3. The seven ecumenical councils at a glance

Council	Date	Primary issue	Major product	Biblical list?
Nicaea I	325	Arian controversy; the Son's full deity	Creed of Nicaea; 20 disciplinary canons	No
Constantinople I	381	Nicene faith; deity of the Holy Spirit; church order	Creed traditionally associated with the 150 fathers; 7 canons	No
Ephesus	431	Nestorius; unity of Christ; Theotokos controversy	Reaffirmed Nicaea; 8 canons; no new rival creed	No
Chalcedon	451	Christ in two natures; Eutyches and Dioscorus	Chalcedonian Definition; disciplinary canons	No
Constantinople II	553	The Three Chapters; interpretation of Chalcedon	Sentence and anathemas	No
Constantinople III	680-681	Monothelitism; Christ's two wills and operations	Definition of faith	No
Nicaea II	787	Iconoclasm and the veneration of images	Doctrinal definition; 22 canons	No

This table does not imply that the later three councils are unimportant. It shows that the recognized ecumenical councils were overwhelmingly concerned with doctrine and discipline. None contains a conciliar vote selecting the books of the Bible.^[1]

4. First Council of Nicaea (AD 325)

Historical setting and purpose

The Arian controversy divided churches over the identity of the Son. Arius taught that the Son, though exalted above creation, did not share the Father's eternal divine essence. Constantine summoned bishops to Nicaea to seek ecclesiastical unity. The council also addressed the Meletian schism in Egypt, the date of Easter, clerical discipline, jurisdiction, and the restoration of people who had lapsed under pressure.

The Creed of Nicaea, written out

The Creed of Nicaea (325)

We believe in one God, the Father Almighty, maker of all things visible and invisible; and in one Lord Jesus Christ, the Son of God, the only-begotten of his Father, of the substance of the Father, God of God, Light of Light, very God of very God, begotten, not made, being of one substance with the Father; by whom all things were made, both in heaven and on earth.

Who for us men and for our salvation came down and was incarnate and was made man. He suffered, and the third day he rose again, and ascended into heaven. And he shall come again to judge both the living and the dead. And we believe in the Holy Spirit.

And those who say, "There was a time when he was not," or "Before he was begotten he was not," or that he was made from things that were not, or that he is of a different substance or essence, or that the Son of God is created, changeable, or alterable - these the catholic and apostolic Church anathematizes.

Public-domain English translation adapted for punctuation from NPNF 2/14. This is not identical to the longer creed commonly recited today.

What its twenty canons actually addressed

The twenty Nicene canons in one-line summary

Canon	Main subject
1	Clergy who had castrated themselves; distinction from involuntary mutilation.
2	Against hasty ordination of recent converts and deposition for grave post-baptismal sin.
3	Restrictions on clergy living with women who were not close relatives.
4	Election and consecration of bishops by the bishops of the province.
5	Review of excommunications and twice-yearly provincial synods.
6	Ancient regional jurisdictions of Alexandria, Rome, Antioch, and other sees.
7	Honor accorded to the bishop of Jerusalem while preserving metropolitan rights.
8	Reception of Novatian clergy and their relationship to Catholic bishops and clergy.
9	Removal of presbyters ordained without examination or despite confessed disqualifying sins.
10	Deposition of clergy who had lapsed during persecution and were later ordained.
11	Penitential discipline for voluntary apostasy under Licinius.
12	Discipline for Christians who returned to military service after renouncing it.
13	Communion for the dying and restoration if the person recovered.
14	Penitential treatment of catechumens who had lapsed.
15	Prohibition on bishops, presbyters, and deacons transferring from city to city.
16	Return of clergy who abandoned their own churches; invalidity of unauthorized ordination elsewhere.
17	Prohibition of clerical usury and financial exploitation.
18	Deacons must not give the Eucharist to presbyters or rank themselves above presbyters.
19	Reception and rebaptism of Paulianists; examination of their clergy and deaconesses.
20	Standing rather than kneeling for prayer on Sundays and during the Pentecost season.

The evidentiary point

A complete survey of the authentic Nicene canons yields rules about clergy, repentance, jurisdiction, worship, and church order - but no list of biblical books and no procedure for voting books into Scripture.

Two common objections

1. Constantine ordered fifty Bibles

Eusebius records that Constantine later ordered fifty copies of the sacred Scriptures for churches in Constantinople. The letter assumes that Eusebius already knew what writings were needed. It does not say that Nicaea chose their contents, and it records no council vote on books.^[7]

2. Jerome says Nicaea counted Judith as Scripture

In his preface to Judith, Jerome says that the book was found by the Nicene Council to have been counted among sacred Scriptures. This statement deserves acknowledgment, but it cannot bear the weight sometimes placed on it. No surviving Nicene creed, canon, synodal letter, or contemporary history preserves a scriptural list. Jerome may be referring to conciliar use or testimony rather than a formal canon decree. His isolated later comment should not be converted into a lost universal Bible vote without corroborating evidence.^[8]

Primary evidence: [1], [7], [8]

5. Synod of Laodicea (c. AD 363-364)

Historical setting and focus

Laodicea was a regional synod in Phrygia, not an ecumenical council. Its canons regulate clergy, liturgical practice, relations with Jews and heretical groups, the conduct of worship, and the ordering of church offices. Its local character matters: a regional rule may reveal the practice of churches in that region without immediately defining universal Christian practice everywhere.

Canons 59 and 60

Canon 59 prohibits private psalms and uncanonical books from being read in church, permitting only canonical books of the Old and New Testaments. A following list, traditionally numbered Canon 60, survives in some manuscript traditions but is absent from others and is explicitly treated as doubtful in older editions. If authentic, its New Testament contains twenty-six books: all of the present New Testament except Revelation.^[2]

- Four Gospels
- Acts
- Seven Catholic Epistles (James; 1-2 Peter; 1-3 John; Jude)
- Fourteen Pauline Epistles, including Hebrews
- Revelation is not listed

Its Old Testament list also differs from both the later Protestant and Roman Catholic arrangements. It includes Baruch and the Letter of Jeremiah with Jeremiah, while omitting Wisdom, Sirach, Tobit, Judith, and Maccabees.

What Laodicea demonstrates - and what it does not

Laodicea demonstrates that churches were regulating liturgical reading and distinguishing canonical from noncanonical writings. It also demonstrates that local lists could differ. If this list "created" the canon,

Revelation would have been excluded. The better explanation is that Laodicea records a regional stage of reception rather than imposing a final universal canon on all Christians.

Why Revelation could differ by region

Revelation was strongly received in much of the West but questioned in parts of the East because of doubts about authorship, difficult interpretation, and controversial uses of apocalyptic or millennial readings. Eusebius himself reflects the divided reception.

Primary evidence: [2], [5]

6. First Council of Constantinople (AD 381)

Historical setting and purpose

Constantinople met under Emperor Theodosius I to secure the Nicene settlement in the East, oppose several anti-Nicene movements, clarify the confession of the Holy Spirit, and settle jurisdictional and episcopal disputes. The council is associated with the form of the creed most Christians now call the Nicene Creed. The historical relationship between the council and the exact text has been discussed by scholars, but Chalcedon in 451 publicly received it as the creed of the 150 fathers.

The Niceno-Constantinopolitan Creed, written out

The Creed associated with Constantinople (381)

We believe in one God, the Father Almighty, maker of heaven and earth and of all things visible and invisible.

And in one Lord Jesus Christ, the only-begotten Son of God, begotten of his Father before all ages, Light of Light, very God of very God, begotten, not made, being of one substance with the Father, by whom all things were made; who for us men and for our salvation came down from heaven and was incarnate by the Holy Spirit and the Virgin Mary, and was made man; and was crucified also for us under Pontius Pilate. He suffered and was buried, and the third day he rose again according to the Scriptures, and ascended into heaven, and sits at the right hand of the Father. And he shall come again with glory to judge both the living and the dead, whose kingdom shall have no end.

And we believe in the Holy Spirit, the Lord and Giver of Life, who proceeds from the Father, who with the Father and the Son together is worshiped and glorified, who spoke by the prophets. And we believe in one holy catholic and apostolic Church. We acknowledge one baptism for the remission of sins. We look for the resurrection of the dead and the life of the world to come. Amen.

Public-domain English translation adapted from NPNF 2/14. The original Greek form says the Spirit proceeds "from the Father"; the later Western filioque is not part of the 381 text.

Its canons

The seven canons traditionally associated with Constantinople

Canon	Main subject
1	Reaffirmation of Nicaea and condemnation of named heresies, including Eunomians, Arians, and Pneumatomachians.
2	Bishops are not to intrude beyond their diocesan boundaries; regional administration is preserved.
3	The bishop of Constantinople receives precedence of honor after

Canon	Main subject
	the bishop of Rome because Constantinople is New Rome.
4	The attempted episcopate of Maximus the Cynic is declared invalid.
5	Reception of a Western statement confessing one Godhead of Father, Son, and Holy Spirit.
6	Rules governing accusations against bishops and excluding malicious or heretical accusers in certain cases.
7	Procedures for receiving converts from different heretical groups; this canon has a complicated textual history.

These canons concern theology, jurisdiction, accusations, and the reception of converts. They contain no list of biblical books.

Primary evidence: [1], [9]

7. Hippo (AD 393) and the African canon tradition

Historical setting

The Synod of Hippo met in North Africa, where Augustine would soon become bishop. Its complete acts do not survive independently, so its canon list is known through later African collections and the repeated decisions of Carthage. This fact requires care: Hippo is important, but the evidence reaches us through subsequent preservation rather than a complete contemporary transcript.

What the African churches agreed to read as Scripture

The African list included the full twenty-seven-book New Testament. Its Old Testament was broader than the later Protestant canon and included Tobit, Judith, Wisdom, Sirach, and two books of Maccabees. The category "five books of Solomon" was normally understood in the African tradition as Proverbs, Ecclesiastes, Song of Songs, Wisdom, and Sirach.

Hippo did not issue a new ecumenical creed and did not claim to create inspiration. Its importance lies in giving regional ecclesiastical form to a list used in the North African churches.

A necessary qualification

When Protestants appeal to Hippo or Carthage because their New Testament matches the present twenty-seven books, they should also notice that the same councils used a broader Old Testament. The evidence is valuable, but it cannot be selectively treated as an infallible universal decree only where it matches a later tradition.

8. Councils of Carthage (AD 397 and 419)

Historical setting and purpose

The North African councils at Carthage addressed an extensive range of disciplinary and administrative matters: clergy, appeals, ordination, church property, relations with schismatic groups, and the conduct of

worship. The canon list appears within this much larger regional code, not as the sole or principal reason for the councils.

The scriptural list

Collection	Books as described in the African code
Old Testament	Genesis; Exodus; Leviticus; Numbers; Deuteronomy; Joshua; Judges; Ruth; four books of Kings; two Chronicles; Job; Psalms; five books of Solomon; the Twelve Prophets; Isaiah; Jeremiah; Ezekiel; Daniel; Tobit; Judith; Esther; two books of Ezra; two Maccabees.
New Testament	Four Gospels; Acts; fourteen Pauline Epistles; two Peter; three John; James; Jude; Revelation.

The most important wording

Carthage on why these books were listed

Besides the canonical Scriptures nothing is to be read in church under the name of divine Scripture... Let this be sent to our brother and fellow bishop Boniface and to the other bishops of those parts, that they may confirm this canon, for these are the things which we have received from our fathers to be read in church.

From the African Code, Canon 24 in the NPNF/New Advent numbering. Punctuation lightly modernized.

Three features are significant. First, the issue is public reading in church. Second, the bishops describe the books as received from their fathers. Third, they seek wider confirmation and correspondence. This is the language of reception, coordination, and regulation, not the language of making previously ordinary books inspired.^[10]

Why Carthage did not instantly settle every Christian canon

Carthage was influential, but it was a regional African council. Different churches continued to preserve somewhat different Old Testament collections, and some Eastern communities continued to differ over a few New Testament books. The council's list is important evidence of North African consensus, not proof of a single fourth-century moment when every Christian everywhere received a newly created Bible.

Primary evidence: [10], [11]

9. Council of Ephesus (AD 431)

Historical setting and focus

Ephesus arose from the controversy involving Nestorius, Cyril of Alexandria, and the language used to speak about Christ and Mary. The central concern was the unity of Christ: the one born of Mary is the eternal Word incarnate, not a separate human person merely associated with the Word. The title Theotokos, "God-bearer" or "Mother of God," functioned as a Christological claim about the identity of the one born, not as a claim that Mary originated the divine nature.

Ephesus did not create a new creed

The council reaffirmed the faith of Nicaea and treated Cyril's letters as doctrinally important. Canon 7 expressly forbade anyone to produce a different faith as a rival to that established at Nicaea.

Ephesus, Canon 7 - modernized rendering

When these things had been read, the holy Synod decreed that it is unlawful for any man to bring forward, write, or compose a different faith as a rival to that established by the holy Fathers assembled with the Holy Spirit at Nicaea. Those who dare to compose or present another faith for converts are subject to deposition if bishops or clergy, and to anathema if laypersons.

Based on the public-domain NPNF translation. Ephesus protects the Nicene faith; it does not issue a biblical book list.

The eight canons

The canons of Ephesus in summary

Canon	Main subject
1	Condemnation of metropolitan bishops who join the rival assembly or embrace Celestian teaching.
2	Discipline for provincial bishops who abandon the council or join the opposing party.
3	Protection of clergy deposed by Nestorian-aligned authorities for remaining orthodox.
4	Deposition of clergy who embrace Nestorian or Celestian teaching.
5	No restoration of persons condemned for misconduct merely because Nestorius favored them.
6	Penalties for those who attempt to overturn the council's decisions.
7	No rival or different faith is to be composed in competition with Nicaea.
8	Protection of the ancient independence of the Church of Cyprus from Antiochene encroachment.

The council's doctrinal and disciplinary material contains no biblical canon list.

Primary evidence: [1], [12]

10. Council of Chalcedon (AD 451)

Historical setting and focus

Chalcedon responded to the aftermath of Ephesus, the teaching of Eutyches, the deposition of Flavian, and the controversial council of 449. It sought language that preserved both the unity of Christ's person and the integrity of his divine and human natures. It publicly recited and received the creeds of Nicaea and Constantinople, the teaching of Cyril, and Leo's Tome.

The Chalcedonian Definition, doctrinal core written out

The Chalcedonian Definition (451) - doctrinal formula

Following the holy Fathers, we all with one voice teach that the Son and our Lord Jesus Christ is to be confessed as one and the same: perfect in Godhead and perfect in manhood, truly God and truly man, consisting of a rational soul and body; of one substance with the Father according to the Godhead, and of one substance with us according to the manhood; like us in all things except sin; begotten before all ages from the Father according to the Godhead, and in these last days, for us and for our salvation, born of the Virgin Mary, the God-bearer, according to the manhood.

One and the same Christ, Son, Lord, and only-begotten is to be acknowledged in two natures, without confusion, without change, without division, and without separation. The distinction of the natures is by no means taken away by the union, but rather the property of each nature is preserved, concurring in one person and one subsistence; not parted or divided into two persons, but one and the same Son and only-begotten, God the Word, the Lord Jesus Christ, as the prophets from the beginning declared concerning him, as the Lord Jesus Christ himself taught us, and as the creed of the Fathers has handed down to us.

Public-domain translation adapted from NPNF 2/14. The four famous adverbs are often summarized as "without confusion, change, division, or separation."

What Chalcedon confirmed

- The Creed of Nicaea (325).
- The creed associated with the 150 fathers at Constantinople (381).
- The council of Ephesus's defense of the same faith.
- Cyril of Alexandria's letters against Nestorius.
- Leo's Tome as consistent with the apostolic and Nicene faith.

The council explicitly described Constantinople's teaching as an explanation of the same faith rather than the introduction of something lacking in Nicaea. This language is itself a model for how ancient councils understood doctrinal development: clarification and defense, not arbitrary invention. ^[13]

Its disciplinary canons

The twenty-eight commonly received Chalcedonian canons in summary

Canon	Main subject
1	Prior ecclesiastical canons are to remain in force.
2	Condemnation of simony in ordinations and church appointments.
3	Clergy and monks are not to manage secular estates for profit except in limited charitable circumstances.
4	Monasteries are subject to episcopal oversight; monks are to remain devoted to their calling.
5	Existing rules against unauthorized transfers of bishops and clergy are reaffirmed.
6	No absolute ordination: clergy must be assigned to a specific church, monastery, or ministry.
7	Clergy and monks are not to enter military or secular office.
8	Clergy attached to charitable institutions and monasteries remain under the local bishop.
9	Clerical disputes should be heard by bishops and appropriate

Canon	Main subject
	ecclesiastical courts.
10	A cleric may not be enrolled simultaneously in two churches.
11	The poor should receive letters of peace rather than commendatory letters intended for honored persons.
12	Civil authorities should not divide provinces in a way that creates rival metropolitan structures.
13	Foreign clergy may not officiate without proper commendatory letters.
14	Rules concerning marriages of readers and cantors and the baptism of their children.
15	Women are not to be ordained as deaconesses before age forty; serious testing is required.
16	Consecrated virgins and monks are not to marry.
17	Rural parishes held for thirty years remain under their bishops; new civil cities affect ecclesiastical order.
18	Conspiracies and organized factions among clergy or monks are condemned.
19	Provincial synods should meet regularly to address ecclesiastical needs.
20	Clergy may not transfer from one city to another without lawful cause and permission.
21	Accusations against bishops or clergy require examination of the accuser's standing and credibility.
22	Clergy may not seize a deceased bishop's property.
23	Disorderly visiting clergy and monks in Constantinople may be expelled if they refuse correction.
24	Monasteries once consecrated are to remain monasteries and not become private property.
25	Metropolitans should not delay the ordination of bishops for vacant sees beyond three months without necessity.
26	Every church should have an official steward to administer property under the bishop.
27	Abduction of women for marriage or complicity in it is punished.
28	Constantinople receives privileges parallel to Old Rome because it is New Rome; this canon became controversial in East-West relations.

Some ancient collections transmit additional items or number them differently. The commonly received Greek tradition counts twenty-eight. Regardless of numbering, the disciplinary material does not contain a biblical book list.

Primary evidence: [1], [13]

11. Why early canon lists could differ

1. Books did not circulate everywhere at the same speed

A short letter such as 2 or 3 John could be known in one region long before copies became common elsewhere. Before printing, broad geographical reception required repeated copying, travel, translation, and use across networks of churches.

2. Apostolic authorship was evaluated, not merely assumed

Hebrews was treasured in the East but faced greater hesitation in parts of the West because it is anonymous and its Pauline authorship was debated. Second Peter, Jude, and 2-3 John also attracted questions about authorship or limited early circulation. The disagreement was not usually over whether their theology was interesting; it was over whether they belonged to the apostolic foundation of the church.

3. Public reading and private edification were different categories

The Shepherd of Hermas, the Didache, 1 Clement, and other writings could be orthodox, ancient, and useful without being treated as apostolic Scripture. Athanasius explicitly distinguishes books in the canon from books appointed to be read to new believers. The Muratorian Fragment similarly allows the Shepherd to be read privately while excluding it from public prophetic or apostolic reading.

4. Revelation and apocalyptic controversy

Revelation was accepted early in many Western churches but disputed in parts of the East. Questions about its author, difficult symbolism, and the use of the book by controversial apocalyptic movements contributed to caution. Laodicea's apparent omission and Eusebius's divided classification preserve this regional history.

5. The Old Testament problem was different from the New Testament problem

Christian churches inherited Scriptures in both Hebrew and Greek forms. The Greek Septuagint tradition included books and expansions not present in the later rabbinic Hebrew collection. Athanasius, Jerome, Augustine, and the African councils did not always draw the canonical/readable boundary in the same place. This is a major reason Protestant, Roman Catholic, and Orthodox Old Testament collections later differed.

6. Book counting and naming were not uniform

Ancient lists may count Samuel and Kings as four "books of Kings," combine the Twelve Minor Prophets as one, combine Ezra and Nehemiah, or refer to "five books of Solomon." Apparent numerical differences can therefore reflect grouping and naming rather than different contents. Conversely, some differences are substantive, such as Revelation's omission at Laodicea or the inclusion of Maccabees at Carthage.

7. Local council authority was not identical to universal reception

A regional synod could regulate its own churches immediately, but other regions did not automatically receive every local decision. Broader consensus emerged through correspondence, use, copying, commentary, lectionaries, and later collections of canons. Carthage's request for confirmation illustrates this networked process.

8. The criteria were cumulative

- Apostolic origin or close apostolic connection.
- Consistency with the inherited rule of faith.
- Antiquity - belonging to the apostolic age rather than a recent composition.
- Broad and sustained use among geographically dispersed churches.
- Suitability for public reading as Scripture rather than merely private instruction.

Why this does not amount to "the church made the Bible"

These criteria describe how churches recognized witnesses they believed were already authoritative. A court

recognizes valid evidence; it does not create the past event to which the evidence testifies. The analogy is imperfect, but it captures the distinction between acknowledging authority and causing authority.

12. Canon lists compared

Witness	New Testament picture	Why it matters
Eusebius, c. 325	Core accepted; James, Jude, 2 Peter, 2-3 John disputed; Revelation divided	Descriptive historical categories, not a council decree
Athanasius, 367	Exactly 27 books	Distinguishes canonical books from useful books appointed for reading
Laodicea, c. 363-364	26 books if Canon 60 is authentic; Revelation omitted	Regional rule for public reading; Canon 60 textually disputed
Hippo, 393	27 books	Regional African list known through later preservation
Carthage, 397/419	27 books	Books received from the fathers to be read in church
Jerome, late 4th c.	27-book NT in practice, while reporting doubts about some books	Narrow Hebrew-based OT canon; other books read ecclesiastically
Augustine, late 4th c.	27-book NT	Broader OT; emphasizes reception by the greater number of churches

Appendix A. Book-by-book New Testament reception matrix

Legend: Accepted / Disputed / Listed / Omitted / Divided. Absence from a damaged fragment does not always prove rejection.

Book	Eusebius c. 325	Athanasius 367	Laodicea Canon 60	Carthage 397/419
Matthew	Accepted	Listed	Listed	Listed
Mark	Accepted	Listed	Listed	Listed
Luke	Accepted	Listed	Listed	Listed
John	Accepted	Listed	Listed	Listed
Acts	Accepted	Listed	Listed	Listed
Romans	Accepted	Listed	Listed	Listed
1 Corinthians	Accepted	Listed	Listed	Listed
2 Corinthians	Accepted	Listed	Listed	Listed
Galatians	Accepted	Listed	Listed	Listed
Ephesians	Accepted	Listed	Listed	Listed
Philippians	Accepted	Listed	Listed	Listed
Colossians	Accepted	Listed	Listed	Listed
1 Thessalonians	Accepted	Listed	Listed	Listed
2 Thessalonians	Accepted	Listed	Listed	Listed
1 Timothy	Accepted	Listed	Listed	Listed
2 Timothy	Accepted	Listed	Listed	Listed
Titus	Accepted	Listed	Listed	Listed
Philemon	Accepted	Listed	Listed	Listed
Hebrews	Included with Paul	Listed	Listed	Listed
James	Disputed	Listed	Listed	Listed
1 Peter	Accepted	Listed	Listed	Listed
2 Peter	Disputed	Listed	Listed	Listed
1 John	Accepted	Listed	Listed	Listed
2 John	Disputed	Listed	Listed	Listed
3 John	Disputed	Listed	Listed	Listed
Jude	Disputed	Listed	Listed	Listed
Revelation	Divided	Listed	Omitted	Listed

The matrix shows why the language of a single decisive council is misleading. By 367 the twenty-seven-book New Testament is explicit in Athanasius; Laodicea may omit Revelation; Carthage includes it. Eusebius preserves the earlier stage in which several short catholic epistles were disputed but known.

Appendix B. Old Testament differences in brief

Witness	Old Testament boundary or principle
Athanasius (367)	A 22-book canonical list arranged to correspond to Hebrew letters; Esther, Wisdom, Sirach, Judith, and Tobit are placed among books for reading rather than the canon; Baruch and the Letter are grouped with Jeremiah.
Laodicea (if Canon 60 authentic)	Includes Baruch and the Letter with Jeremiah; omits Wisdom, Sirach, Tobit, Judith, and Maccabees.
Carthage	Includes Tobit, Judith, two Maccabees, and five books of Solomon, conventionally including Wisdom and Sirach.
Jerome	Prefers the Hebrew 22-book collection for canonical proof; treats Wisdom, Sirach, Judith, Tobit, and Maccabees as outside that canon while allowing ecclesiastical reading.
Augustine	Uses the broader African collection and advises giving priority to books received by the greater number and more prominent churches.

The Old Testament evidence is a warning against oversimplification. The early church did not always use "canonical," "ecclesiastical," and "readable" with perfectly uniform boundaries. Later confessional traditions resolved these questions differently.

13. Final conclusions

1. Nicaea did not establish a biblical canon. Its surviving creed and twenty canons concern Christology, discipline, jurisdiction, repentance, and worship.
2. Constantinople, Ephesus, and Chalcedon produced or confirmed creeds and doctrinal definitions, not lists of biblical books.
3. Laodicea is the earliest council in this study directly regulating canonical reading, but its list is regional, textually disputed, and apparently omits Revelation.
4. Hippo and Carthage are major witnesses to a twenty-seven-book New Testament in North Africa, but their own language describes books received from the fathers for church reading.
5. Differences were concentrated mainly at the edges of the New Testament and were larger for the Old Testament because of Hebrew and Greek textual traditions.
6. The most accurate summary is recognition, reception, regulation, and confirmation - not invention.

Recommended wording

"The early church did not create Scripture by council vote. The churches gradually recognized apostolic books, and later bishops and regional councils recorded and regulated that inherited consensus. Nicaea itself did not decide the biblical canon."

Primary sources and evidence notes

- [1] Philip Schaff and Henry Wace, eds., *Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers, Second Series*, vol. 14, *The Seven Ecumenical Councils*. Contains the creeds, definitions, canons, letters, and historical introductions for Nicaea, Constantinople, Ephesus, Chalcedon, and the African code. [Online text](#)
- [2] Synod of Laodicea, Canons 59-60. Canon 60 is marked as of questionable genuineness in the NPNF/New Advent presentation. [Online text](#)
- [3] Eusebius, *Ecclesiastical History* 3.25, distinguishing accepted, disputed, and rejected writings. [Online text](#)
- [4] The Muratorian Fragment. Its date and reconstruction are debated; it remains an important early witness to a Roman or Western collection and to the distinction between public scriptural reading and useful private reading. [Online text](#)
- [5] Eusebius, *Ecclesiastical History* 3.25 and 6.25, preserving discussion of disputed catholic epistles, Revelation, Hebrews, and Origen's testimony. [Online text](#)
- [6] Athanasius, *Thirty-Ninth Festal Letter* (367), listing the twenty-seven New Testament books and distinguishing books appointed for reading. [Online text](#)
- [7] Eusebius, *Life of Constantine* 4.36, Constantine's order for fifty copies of the sacred Scriptures for Constantinople. [Online text](#)
- [8] Jerome, *Preface to Judith*, mentioning Nicaea and Judith. The statement is later and is not supported by a surviving Nicene book list. [Online text](#)
- [9] First Council of Constantinople: creed and canons in NPNF 2/14. [Online text](#)
- [10] African Code / Council of Carthage, Canon 24, listing books and stating they were received from the fathers to be read in church. [Online text](#)
- [11] Augustine, *On Christian Doctrine* 2.8, advising interpreters to weigh reception among the greater number and more prominent churches. [Online text](#)
- [12] Council of Ephesus, Canon 7, forbidding a rival faith to the Nicene confession. [Online text](#)
- [13] Council of Chalcedon, *Definition of Faith*, explicitly receiving Nicaea, Constantinople, Cyril, Ephesus, and Leo. [Online text](#)

Selected modern scholarship

- F. F. Bruce, *The Canon of Scripture* (InterVarsity Press, 1988).
- Bruce M. Metzger, *The Canon of the New Testament: Its Origin, Development, and Significance* (Oxford University Press, 1987).
- Edmon L. Gallagher and John D. Meade, *The Biblical Canon Lists from Early Christianity: Texts and Analysis* (Oxford University Press, 2017).
- Michael J. Kruger, *Canon Revisited: Establishing the Origins and Authority of the New Testament Books* (Crossway, 2012).
- Lee Martin McDonald, *The Biblical Canon: Its Origin, Transmission, and Authority*, 3rd ed. (Hendrickson, 2007).

Translation note: the creeds and conciliar texts are based on public-domain English translations in the Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers. Spelling and punctuation have been lightly modernized for readability.

Scope note: this study addresses the historical role of councils. It does not settle whether church recognition is merely historical, providential, or institutionally authoritative; Christian traditions answer that question differently.